

TAKING CHARGE
The new head of state inspects the guard of honour at Rashtrapati Bhavan

mobilise themselves into powerful political groupings, the tribals remain far more disadvantaged.

Ninety per cent of them live in rural areas. The tragedy is that they continue to be the most deprived communities when compared to mainstream India in terms of poverty, health, education, and other critical socio-economic indices. The last census that the country conducted, in 2011, showed 45 per cent of the tribals below the poverty line as compared to 26 per cent in the rest of rural India. When it comes to health, infant mortality rates, under-5 mortality rate and underweight children too, they again fare much worse than the general population. Literacy levels are low as well—only 59 per cent of the tribals are literate, compared to the national average of 74 per cent. One outcome of this is that no Adivasi has been elevated to the Supreme Court as a judge so far.

MAKING MURMU PRESIDENT IS A FIRST STEP TOWARD ENDING MARGIN-MAINSTREAM, TRIBAL-NON-TRIBAL BINARIES FOR BJP

PLIGHT OF THE TRIBALS

Their economic condition also remains abysmal. For the Adivasis, *jal*, *jangal* and *jameen* are critical to their livelihood. But they face the maximum pressure on their land ownership as much of it has been appropriated for mining and mineral resources as well as for hydel projects and industry. That has turned them into landless labourers and forced them to migrate to distant towns and cities in search of work. Taking advantage of their plight, Maoist insurgency has also taken root in some of the areas that tribals inhabit. Professor Virginius Xaxa, an expert on tribal affairs and a tribal himself, pointed out in a recent interview, "The kind of exploitation that tribals experienced during the colonial period is being repeated in more systematic and aggressive ways today in the name of development."

Murmu herself came from this background of deprivation. Her father Biranchi Narayan Tudu was a marginal farmer, who had studied up to only Class II. Luckily for Murmu, she was the only girl in a family of predominantly male members, and therefore her father's favourite.